

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Supply Chain and Logistics English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Demand planning exception

02 A component shortage

03 Inventory accuracy

04 Dock congestion

05 A customs document mismatch

06 Carrier performance review

07 Supplier recovery plan

08 Disruption handoff

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Demand planning exception

Sales and planning review a sudden forecast increase.

Roles: Demand planner / Sales manager

Demand planner: Your forecast doubles next month's demand. Is that confirmed business or pipeline?

Sales manager: Half is a signed promotion; the rest depends on a retailer's decision.

Demand planner: Then I'll separate the committed volume from the upside scenario.

Sales manager: Can procurement reserve capacity for both?

Demand planner: We can ask about options, but a reservation may carry a fee or minimum commitment.

Sales manager: I'll confirm the retailer's decision date and cancellation terms.

Demand planner: Good. We'll review the supply exposure before releasing additional purchase orders.

Sales manager: I'll also remove the duplicate opportunity from the sales forecast.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Your forecast doubles next month's demand. Is that confirmed business or pipeline?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A component shortage

A buyer and planner discuss a late component shipment.

Roles: Buyer / Supply planner

Buyer: The supplier pushed the connector delivery back five days.

Supply planner: Our available stock covers only three production days. Is there a partial shipment?

Buyer: They can offer 600 units early, pending final inspection.

Supply planner: That would protect the priority order. What is the additional freight cost?

Buyer: I'm waiting on the quote. I haven't authorized expedited freight.

Supply planner: Send the quantity, confirmed ship date, and cost together.

Buyer: I'll get a written commitment from the supplier.

Supply planner: I'll model the remaining gap and flag orders needing revised promise dates.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Our available stock covers only three production days. Is there a partial shipment?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Inventory accuracy

A warehouse count differs from the planning system.

Roles: Inventory controller / Warehouse supervisor

Inventory controller: The system shows 480 units, but the cycle count found 430.

Warehouse supervisor: Were the 50 units in the returns cage included?

Inventory controller: They were physically counted separately. Their inspection status is still pending.

Warehouse supervisor: Then they're not available-to-promise stock.

Inventory controller: Right. I need to reconcile the status before requesting an adjustment.

Warehouse supervisor: Check yesterday's transfer and return transactions as well.

Inventory controller: I'll retain both count sheets and investigate the movement history.

Warehouse supervisor: Let planning know that only the verified saleable quantity is available.

Notice the professional language

cycle count - A recurring count of selected inventory items to check record accuracy.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Dock congestion

A warehouse team has more outbound orders than dispatch capacity.

Roles: Warehouse manager / Transport coordinator

Warehouse manager: We have 130 orders still waiting. Which can make today's collection?

Transport coordinator: The carrier has room for 80. The rest need another collection or tomorrow's run.

Warehouse manager: Prioritize the orders with today's committed dispatch date.

Transport coordinator: Some of those aren't picked yet. Can we move them into the next picking wave?

Warehouse manager: Yes. I'll resequence picking without mixing customer labels.

Transport coordinator: I'll request an additional vehicle and confirm the surcharge.

Warehouse manager: Don't promise same-day dispatch until the capacity is confirmed.

Transport coordinator: Agreed. Customer service will receive the final exception list at cutoff.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We have 130 orders still waiting. Which can make today's collection?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A customs document mismatch

A shipment is awaiting clarification at the destination port.

Roles: Customs broker / Logistics coordinator

Customs broker: The commercial invoice and packing list show different quantities.

Logistics coordinator: The invoice lists 100 cartons; the packing list lists 96. I'll check the loading record.

Customs broker: Please obtain corrected documents from the responsible shipper. Don't just edit the figures here.

Logistics coordinator: Does the tariff classification need review too?

Customs broker: The product description is incomplete, so classification needs confirmation from the appropriate specialist.

Logistics coordinator: I'll request the detailed specification and reconcile the carton count.

Customs broker: Once those are available, we can assess the entry requirements.

Logistics coordinator: I'll tell the customer clearance remains pending and avoid promising a delivery date.

Notice the professional language

commercial invoice - A trade document describing the goods sold and relevant transaction details.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Carrier performance review

Procurement challenges a carrier's on-time delivery report.

Roles: Procurement manager / Carrier account manager

Procurement manager: Your scorecard says 96 percent on time. Ours says 89 percent.

Carrier account manager: We measure arrival within the booked delivery day. What window are you using?

Procurement manager: The appointment slot, including rejected deliveries. Are those in your denominator?

Carrier account manager: No. We excluded failed delivery attempts.

Procurement manager: That explains part of the gap. Let's reconcile shipment IDs before discussing remedies.

Carrier account manager: I'll send the event-level records and exclusion rules.

Procurement manager: We'll agree on one definition for next month's review.

Carrier account manager: And I'll separately investigate the repeated misses at the northern distribution center.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We measure arrival within the booked delivery day. What window are you using?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Supplier recovery plan

A supplier has missed two weekly commitments.

Roles: Supplier development lead / Supplier production manager

Supplier development lead: We need a recovery plan tied to actual capacity. What is constraining output?

Supplier production manager: Final test is the bottleneck. The second fixture is still being qualified.

Supplier development lead: What can the current fixture deliver reliably?

Supplier production manager: About 200 units a day on the present shift pattern.

Supplier development lead: Show that as the base plan. Keep the second fixture as a conditional improvement.

Supplier production manager: I'll include daily milestones and the qualification decision date.

Supplier development lead: Please also identify the owner for each action.

Supplier production manager: I'll send the plan today and report shipment quantities against it each morning.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We need a recovery plan tied to actual capacity. What is constraining output?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Disruption handoff

A storm has interrupted a planned delivery route.

Roles: Logistics coordinator / Customer service lead

Logistics coordinator: The linehaul is delayed, and the carrier hasn't confirmed a revised arrival.

Customer service lead: Do we know which customer orders are on the trailer?

Logistics coordinator: Yes. I've attached the manifest and the last verified tracking event.

Customer service lead: Can we offer delivery tomorrow?

Logistics coordinator: Not yet. The alternate route is still being assessed.

Customer service lead: I'll explain the delay and give customers a time for the next update.

Logistics coordinator: I'll own the carrier follow-up and flag any confirmed change immediately.

Customer service lead: I'll record individual customer constraints so we can prioritize when capacity returns.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Do we know which customer orders are on the trailer?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

SHARED CASE

A forecast exceeds actual demand for three months. Sales expects a new promotion to improve demand but has no order evidence yet.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The forecast has been above actual demand for three months. The promotion may change that pattern, but it is still an assumption. I'll separate confirmed orders from the promotional estimate.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Procurement and Supplier Performance

SHARED CASE

A supplier acknowledges an order but gives no shipping date. The planning team needs a date to update its schedule.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the planned ship date and any quantity that will remain outstanding? Please distinguish a confirmed commitment from a provisional estimate so we can update the schedule accurately.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

SHARED CASE

A warehouse has high total inventory but repeated stockouts of two important items. A manager asks why the headline total looks healthy.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The total inventory value hides differences between items. We have stock in some products but shortages in two others. Let's review availability by item and expected demand.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Warehousing and Fulfillment

SHARED CASE

A fulfillment team starts with 300 open orders and ships 220. Fifty new orders arrive during the shift.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

We shipped 220 orders, and 50 new orders arrived. The backlog is now 130 orders. I'll include both completed work and incoming demand so the change is clear.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

SHARED CASE

A carrier estimates delivery on Wednesday but has not confirmed departure. A customer asks for a guaranteed arrival time.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Wednesday is the carrier's current estimate, not a confirmed arrival. Departure is still pending. I'll send the next update when the carrier confirms the shipment status.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

SHARED CASE

A shipment file contains different product descriptions on the invoice and packing list. The broker requests clarification.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The descriptions do not match across the documents. Could the responsible team confirm the correct product details and provide consistent records for the broker's review?

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Supply Risk and Business Continuity

SHARED CASE

One supplier has a shorter lead time; a second has available backup capacity. The team is considering supply continuity options.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The first supplier offers speed, while the second may provide backup capacity. Let's compare availability, qualification status, and switching constraints before treating either option as a complete continuity solution.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Executive S&OP Decisions

SHARED CASE

Sales and operations propose different monthly plans. The meeting has ten minutes left and no agreed assumption about the promotion.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The unresolved assumption is promotional demand. Could we compare the two plans using the same assumption, then record the chosen plan, its owner, and the condition that would trigger a review?

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.